Lesson 3 — The Night the Network Failed

Part 1 of 12: Passage — The Night the Network Failed

Level: A2 (third step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

> How to do the listening. Same rule as Lessons 1 and 2: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-weak-forms.mp3` is new — the weak sounds of was and were.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. Where do you keep the work you are doing now?
2. What do you do when the electricity stops in the middle of your work?
3. How many copies of your most important file do you have?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Night the Network Failed (320 words)

Last March, Omar was finishing his final project at the computer centre. He was studying software engineering, and the project was the most important work of his year. The college wanted it on Friday morning.

[A] On Tuesday evening, he was sitting at his usual desk. The room was quiet. Three other students were working near the window, and the lights were low. Omar was uploading his files to the college server when the screen stopped moving.

At first he was not worried. The internet in the building was often slow, so he waited. He checked the cable. He restarted the browser. Nothing changed on the screen. The upload was stuck at sixty per cent.

[B] Then the lights went out. The electricity was off, and the room was completely dark. The other students were laughing, because this happened almost every week. Omar was not laughing. His computer turned off while it was writing to the server, and he did not know which files arrived and which did not.

When the power came back, twenty minutes later, he opened his folder again. The file was there, but it was broken. The computer could not open it. He tried it again, and then he tried it on another machine. Three months of work were inside that file.

[C] Then he remembered something his teacher said in the first week: "Save often, and save in two places." He opened his email. While he was uploading the file that evening, he also sent a copy to himself — not because he was careful, but because he wanted to read it at home.

The copy was from Sunday. It was two days old.

[D] Omar finished the project that night. He slept for four hours. In the morning, before his class, he bought a small USB drive. Now, when he is working on something important, he saves it in three places: the computer, his email, and the drive.

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Compare it with your Lesson 2 recording: are you stopping less often?